



6 Poetry: voice, form and imagery

Literary forms · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Poetic voice refers to the persona or speaker constructed by the poem, which may or may not align with the poet's own views. Form (fixed forms like sonnets, or free verse) shapes rhythm and expectation, while imagery (sensory and figurative language) creates meaning through comparison and connotation rather than direct statement. Analysing a poem well means treating voice, form, and imagery as interconnected rather than separate checklist items.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Consider an invented poem written entirely in unpunctuated free verse about a garden left untended. A model analytical point: 'The absence of punctuation throughout mimics the garden's own lack of boundaries, so that form (unbroken syntax) and image (an untended, sprawling garden) reinforce a single idea: the collapse of ordered control.' This shows form and imagery working together rather than being discussed in isolation.

Quick check · multiple choice

The 'speaker' or 'persona' of a poem should be understood as:

- A Always identical to the poet's own biographical views
- B A constructed voice that may differ from the poet, created for the poem's purposes
- C Irrelevant to the poem's meaning
- D Only present in poems written in first person

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Analyse the following invented couplet in relation to voice, form, and imagery: 'I keep your name folded like a map I will not read, / afraid the roads have changed and I no longer lead.' Discuss how the imagery of the folded, unread map constructs the speaker's emotional state, and comment on the effect of the rhyme. [20]

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [20]

- Point 1: the extended metaphor of the folded map suggests memory or relationship treated as a resource deliberately left unused, implying avoidance rather than forgetting.
- Point 2: 'afraid the roads have changed' extends the map conceit to suggest fear of confronting change in a relationship or in oneself, layering emotional vulnerability onto a spatial image.
- Point 3: the rhyme ('read'/'lead') creates closure and a sense of resigned inevitability, reinforcing the speaker's passive stance ('I no longer lead').
- Point 4: the first-person confessional voice creates intimacy, positioning the reader almost as a confidant privy to a private admission of fear.
- Conclusion: argue that voice, image, and rhyme jointly construct a persona defined by avoidance rather than resolution.

Quick check answer

B. The speaker is a constructed voice; conflating speaker and poet without evidence is a common analytical error.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English A: Literature guide (2019).

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